

MANUALLY OPERATED REPEATING RIFLES

There had been attempts to produce “repeater,” or multiple-shot, rifles and muskets as early as the 16th century. Notwithstanding the success enjoyed by the percussion revolvers of Colt and others (see pp.88–93), it took the unitary cartridge containing primer, charge, and projectile in one package (see pp.112–13) to make the repeating rifle a satisfactory reality in the mid-19th century. Contained in magazines carrying set numbers of cartridges, the ammunition of a repeating rifle was fed to its breech as part of the single action that cleared the chamber of a spent cartridge case, cocked the action, and readied the gun for firing.

▼ HENRY MODEL 1860

Date 1860

Origin US

Barrel 20in (51cm)

Caliber .44in rim-fire

When Oliver Winchester set up the New Haven Arms Co. (see p.119), he brought in Benjamin Tyler Henry to run it. Henry's first act was to design a lever-action repeating rifle worked by an under-lever that ejected the spent round, chambered a new one, and left the action cocked. This rifle carried a magazine with 15 rounds. Magazines evolved various forms, the most common of which was tubular, with cartridges stacked in a horizontal row.



FULL VIEW



▲ SPENCER RIFLE

Date 1863

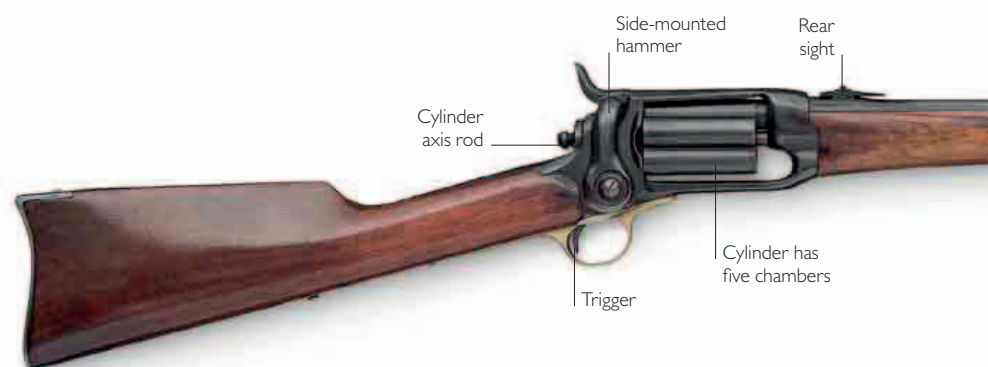
Origin US

Barrel 28¼in (72cm)

Caliber .52in

The lever-action Spencer, which had a tubular seven-round magazine in its butt, was the world's first practical military repeating rifle. It was adopted by the Union Army in the American Civil War.

Butt contains tubular magazine, holding seven rounds



▲ COLT REVOLVING RIFLE

Date 1855

Origin US

Barrel 26¾in (68.2cm)

Caliber .56in

Of Colt's earliest revolving rifles (see pp.122–23), this one made a considerable impact, even though its loading procedure was cumbersome. The cylinder was removed, powder packed into the five chambers, a bullet packed on top, and the chambers sealed with wax in order to protect against the possibility of igniting all the chambers at once.

